

THE LITTLE MERMAID

A PANTOMIME BY NICK LAWRENCE

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REVISED APRIL 2026

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Scenes & Songs

Act One.....	6
Prologue: Beneath the Waves.....	6
Scene One: Beneath the Waves.....	8
Song: Ensemble & FLANDERS.....	8
Scene Two: The Singing Lesson.....	13
Song: Dame Beluga.....	14
Song: Ariel.....	16
Scene Three: Aboard the Ship.....	19
Song: Evan, Willis and Ensemble.....	19
Scene Four: The Shore.....	24
Song: Ariel & Evan.....	25
Scene Five: The Bargain.....	27
Song: Dame Beluga, Marina, FLANDERS, Spirit of the Sea, Theodore and Ensemble.....	33
Act Two.....	34
Scene Six: The Royal Palace.....	34
Song: Evan, Willis and Ensemble.....	34
Scene Seven: Beneath the Waves.....	40
Scene Eight: Octavia's Lair.....	43
Song: Octavia and Ensemble.....	43
Scene Nine: Back on Dry Land.....	48
Scene Ten: The Wedding.....	51
Song: Full Cast.....	54
Scene Eleven: On the Shore.....	55
Scene Twelve: Finale/Bows.....	56

List of Characters

Ariel: Titular heroine who dreams of the surface.

Dame Beluga: The Royal Singing Teacher.

FLANDERS: Comic. Ariel's best friend.

Queen Marina: Queen under the sea. Ariel's mother.

Octavia: The baddie. Queen Marina's sister.

Theodore: A Lobster. Queen Marina's right-hand man.

Prince Evan: Principal boy and Ariel's love interest.

King Godfrey: Prince Evan's father.

Willis: Prince Evan's friend and confidante.

Slip and Slap: Octavia's hapless henchmen.

The Spirit of the Sea: A good fairy. Ariel's spiritual guide and storyteller.

Persil, Lenor, Daz and Own Brand: Ariel's sisters.

Ensemble: Mermaids, Sea-creatures, Sailors, Citizens, Guards & Jellyfish etc.

Author's Notes

Taking panto from Page to Stage...

Year-round Pantomimes

Panto is most popular during December and the Christmas season; however, more and more productions are taking place at other times of year. If required you are permitted to change seasonal Christmas references to something more seasonably appropriate.

The Cue-Card Scene (Scene Six)

Ariel communicates with Evan using a stack of large hand-lettered cards in a homage to the same scene in the film *Love Actually*. The underscore music is flexible, "Silent Night" is used in the film, but any similar music works too. Don't forget to make the cards large enough to be clearly readable by those on the back row!

The Voice-Passing Routine (Scene Eight)

In this scene, Ariel's voice, released from the shell, passes between characters as a spotlight moves between them. The actor playing Ariel speaks the lines from offstage while each character lip-syncs in turn. The spotlights can be preset from above, with specific places for the actors to stand beneath them, or a follow-spot can flick between them: whatever works best for you!

Act One

Prologue: Beneath the Waves

TABS CLOSED

There is a magical sound as THE SPIRIT OF THE SEA enters. She addresses the AUDIENCE.

SPIRIT Good evening, dear friends, and welcome to you,
It's time for our panto, there's lots to get through.
I'm the Spirit of the Sea, and I've come here tonight,
To set the scene properly, and start our tale right.

Deep beneath the surface, under the sea,
There is a kingdom of wonders, but it's not Disney,
We have to be different, so have added some twists,
Or we might get in trouble with the copyright-ists!

Our story retains the undersea realm,
Queen Marina is monarch and steadies the helm.
Her trident holds power and she sits on the throne,
But her sister is jealous and wants it for her own.

There is an evil chord. OCTAVIA enters. The AUDIENCE boo.

OCTAVIA **(Savouring the boos)** I knew you lot would start early on the boos!

SPIRIT This is Octavia, she's a Sea-Witch,
She's the Queen's sister and a bit of a... handful.
She longs for the trident and covets the crown,
She's making her plans to bring the Queen down.

OCTAVIA Not just the Queen, I want to get rid of them all, and Ariel most of all!

SPIRIT Ariel's a princess, Marina's first daughter,
She's heir to the throne and all underwater,
But that is not all, she's also been blessed,
With a voice that, quite simply, is the very best.

OCTAVIA **(To the AUDIENCE)** It's just a shame such a talent has been wasted on such a silly princess. That voice should be mine, and the trident too!

SPIRIT Oh please stop your plotting, you know you can't win,
Besides, it's now time for our show to begin,
You can't have her voice, it wouldn't be fair,
Now off you go, go back to your lair.

OCTAVIA Fine, but this isn't the last you've heard of me!

An evil chord plays as OCTAVIA exits, laughing.

SPIRIT I wish I could say, that was just a phase,
But she'll still be the same when she next takes the stage,
Now let us begin, our story is set,
So come underwater, and try not to get wet!

THE SPIRIT OF THE SEA exits. Music starts for the opening number.

TABS OPEN. END OF SCENE

Scene One: Beneath the Waves

TABS OPEN

The stage is bright and colourful. The **ENSEMBLE**, as mermaids, fish and sea creatures, sing and dance the opening number. **FLANDERS** is among them.

CYCLEORAMA – busy coral reef with fish and sea creatures

Song: Ensemble & FLANDERS – ROCK LOBSTER

The number ends. **FLANDERS** steps forward and addresses the **AUDIENCE**.

FLANDERS Hello everyone and welcome to the Coral, our underwater habitat of happiness and haddock that's fishier than a suspicious-looking salmon! My name is **FLANDERS** and I'm a... well, I'm a **FLANDERS**. **(Beat)** It's terrific to meet you, although by the looks of things, you don't seem very well prepared. We're hundreds of metres beneath the sea and you haven't got a snorkel between you!

CHARL' The Spirit of the Sea probably enchanted them to breathe underwater.

Everyone nods in agreement.

FLANDERS I think you might be right. I tell you, that fairy's got more spirit than the Queen's drinks cabinet!

SCARL' Speaking of the Queen, isn't she due here for the State of the Sea address?

FLANDERS She certainly is. **(To the AUDIENCE)** Every year Queen Marina addresses the people of the Coral. It's just like the King's Speech, but wetter.

PAUL' Have you seen the state of the sea lately? It's full of microplastics and drinking straws.

FLANDERS I know, and we absolutely need to sort it out. But microplastics don't make great material for panto.

KANDY They're not great material for the ocean either!

FLANDERS Touché.

THEODORE enters, self-important and slightly out of breath.

THEO **(Entering, grandly)** Stand aside! Make way! I am Lobster Theodore; Her Majesty's Most Loyal Hermit, Guarder of the Oysters, Keeper of the Pearls, Defender of the Reef, and Generally Snappy Dresser!

FLANDERS **(To the AUDIENCE)** He always has these unnecessarily long titles. Last time he introduced himself I missed the tide.

PAUL' And as for snappy dresser, you should see him on casual Fridays.

THEO **(Bristling)** Excuse me... For I am Lobster Theodore, Her Majesty's Most Loyal Hermit...

FLANDERS **(Interrupting)** Yes, yes, we know. Do you have to say the whole thing every time?

THEO Of course I do, for I am Lobster Theodore, Her Majesty's Most...

ALL **(Interrupting)** Alright!

FLANDERS Why are you here and what do you want?

THEO Some respect. Just a little bit.

FLANDERS **(Cheekily)** OK, Aretha Franklin.

THEO That is NOT my name!

FLANDERS We know. It's Lobster Theodore...

As FLANDERS says the name, members of the ENSEMBLE begin joining in, one title at a time, until all are speaking in unison.

S & SIS Her Majesty's Most Loyal Hermit... Guarder of the Oysters... Keeper of the Pearls... Defender of the Reef...

ALL And Generally Snappy Dresser!

THEO **(Satisfied despite himself)** Precisely. Now, Queen Marina is on her way with her daughters for the State of the Sea address and she's not in the finest of moods.

FLANDERS Why not?

THEO Because Ariel is missing.

Everyone gasps dramatically.

CHARL' She's always swimming off.

SCARL' I reckon she'll be looking for humans again.

THEO **(Sharply)** Don't say the H-word. Her Majesty doesn't like it.

FLANDERS **(To the AUDIENCE)** Many years ago, the Queen's parents were caught in fishing nets and never came back. So, you can understand why she's not their biggest fin.

There is a fanfare. QUEEN MARINA enters.

THEO **(Announcing grandly)** Please welcome her most esteemed majesty and ruler beneath the waves: Queen Marina!

The MERMAIDES applaud.

MARINA **(To the AUDIENCE/ENSEMBLE)** Hello everyone, it's lovely to see you all. Now, where is Ariel?

THEO She's just... she'll be along...

MARINA She's not here, is she.

THEO No, ma'am.

MARINA **(Sighing)** Theodore, why don't you introduce my daughters while I try not to have a royal meltdown.

THEO Of course, Your Majesty. **(To the AUDIENCE)** Ladies and gentlemen, lionfish and guppies, may I present Her Majesty's daughters. First, Charlotte!

MARINA My eldest. Still as smart and fresh as the day she was born.

CHARLOTTE steps forward and curtseys.

THEO Scarlotte!

MARINA So soft and gentle she could calm a raging sea.

SCARLOTTE steps forward and curtseys.

THEO Paulette!

MARINA A true beauty who dazzles us with her charm.

PAULETTE steps forward and curtseys.

THEO And... Kandy with a K.

MARINA **(Warm, but less gushing)** Hello, dear.

KANDY I'm just as good as the others!

FLANDERS And significantly cheaper.

MARINA **(Back to the matter at hand)** Now, Theodore, where is Ariel?

THEO My best intelligence suggests she's been in her treasure grotto, Your Majesty.

CHARL' She spends hours up there.

SCARL' Polishing her collection of strange objects.

PAUL' Combs made of metal.

KANDY Cups made of plastic.

FLANDERS You should see those four-pronged stabby things.

MARINA I couldn't give a fork! **(Beat)** Human made objects aren't safe and I won't have my daughter putting herself in danger. **(Beat)** And I worry about my sister, Octavia. Ariel is impressionable, and Octavia is not to be trusted. She's been jealous since I inherited the trident, and I wouldn't put it past her to try and use Ariel to get to me.

THEO Quite right, ma'am.

ARIEL enters, clutching something behind her back.

MARINA Ariel, there you are, what have you been doing?

ARIEL Sorry mother, I got distracted.

MARINA By what?

ARIEL hesitates, then produces the object from behind her back. It is a child's toy - the latest craze and most desirable object! Everyone gasps.

MARINA **(Staring at it)** What in the seven seas is that?

ARIEL Isn't it wonderful?

MARINA It certainly is not! What is that even *for*?

ARIEL I don't know. But someone made it. With hands. With imagination. Somewhere above us. Don't you think that's amazing?

THEO Actually Ma'am, I've seen one of those before, it's a very complicated tool with sophisticated abilities and uses... Well, either that or it's a child's toy.

MARINA You're to get rid of it immediately.

ARIEL But mother!

MARINA Don't 'but mother' me. I'm at the end of my tail with you. You're late for the State of the Sea address, and why, because you're obsessed with humans.

ARIEL But don't you ever wonder what it's like up there? Doesn't it matter?

MARINA What matters to me is your safety, humans are dangerous! Besides, you are a princess of the Coral. Your place is here, your future is here and the surface is forbidden. Do you understand me?

ARIEL I understand you perfectly, but you're not even trying to understand me.

ARIEL runs offstage, upset. Beat.

THEO I think she might be upset, your majesty.

MARINA Don't take that tone with me, Lobster... or I'll have you Theodored!

THEO **(Laughing)** Theodored... like Thermidored... very funny your majesty.

No one else laughs.

I'll go after her, shall I? **(He exits after ARIEL)**

TABS CLOSE. END OF SCENE.

Scene Two: The Singing Lesson

TABS CLOSED

DAME BELUGA enters. She sees the AUDIENCE and is immediately delighted.

DAME Hello and welcome. Look at you all! Are you enjoying yourselves?

The AUDIENCE responds.

DAME Sorry? ARE you enjoying yourselves?

The AUDIENCE responds louder.

DAME Ah, it's much better when you reply with a bit of volume. It's absolutely essential in my profession, for I am Dame Beluga; Royal Singing Teacher of the Seven Seas and recipient of the Classical Coral Conservatoire's Certificate of Choral Commendation. Try saying that quickly! **(Beat)** There's nothing I love more than teaching people to sing, in fact, I have devoted my entire career to saving the wails. Now, I wonder if there are any singing sensations here tonight, shall we have a look at you?

The houselights come up.

Wow-wee! You lot are quite the catch, and I mean that in the nicest possible aquatic way. **(Pointing at a man in the AUDIENCE)** Look at this gentleman, he looks just like my late husband... I'll let you decide if that's a compliment or not! My husband was wonderful, a keen sportsman and passionate about seahorse riding. Unfortunately, though, he was very allergic and swelled up right in the saddle. But at least he went out in a canter. But ever since then I've been on my own and I've been very lonely,

The AUDIENCE 'Aww'.

I'm more lonely than that

The AUDIENCE 'Aww' again.

I'm even more lonely than that

The AUDIENCE 'Aww' again.

Alright, I'm not that lonely. But it can't hurt to have a look now, can it.

She chooses a man in the AUDIENCE.

You there! What's your name?

The man responds.

Oh, **(NAME OF MAN)**, that's a lovely name! Let's do some aural practice, shall we? Open your mouth... **(Beat)** Wider, wider... Ooh, you've got lovely tonsils! Have you had any formal vocal training? No? Then how about I do a little demo for you, would you like that? **(Regardless of their response)** No, oh well, I'm going to do it anyway!

Song: Dame Beluga – FEELING GOOD

The song ends and ARIEL and FLANDERS enter.

DAME Aha, there you are Ariel, ready for your singing lesson?

FLANDERS I can't sing, I'll leave you to it!

DAME Nonsense, everyone can sing. Ariel, give us an arpeggio please.

ARIEL sings a perfect arpeggio.

DAME Lovely. And now you FLANDERS.

FLANDERS sings. Not perfect, but not terrible.

DAME See, I knew you could do it. **(She turns to the man in the AUDIENCE)** And now... **(NAME OF MAN)**, your turn.

DAME BELUGA, ARIEL and FLANDERS turn to look at the man in the AUDIENCE. As soon as he starts singing they all cover their ears in horror.

Stop, stop that immediately!

ARIEL Oh come on Dame Beluga, it wasn't that bad!

DAME Not that bad, I've heard banshees with better tuning!

FLANDERS Maybe we should do a warmup before we sing?

ARIEL Excellent idea. Where do we start?

DAME **(As if obvious)** Where do we start? From the top of course!

FLANDERS I never knew that!

DAME It's the first rule of singing! And if you don't know that, there's no point in continuing! In fact, I think we should drill that into all of you first.

ARIEL But how?

DAME It's perfectly simple. Whenever I say, "Where do we start?" you respond "From the top!" **(Turning to the AUDIENCE)** In fact, you can all join in too. Whenever you hear "Where do we start?" you reply "From the top!" Ok? Let's give it a go... Where do we start?

The AUDIENCE, ARIEL and FLANDERS reply “From the top!” Beat. DAME BELUGA didn’t hear them.

Have you done it yet?

ARIEL We just did.

DAME Well I didn’t hear it. Let’s try again, but louder, alright... Where do we start?

The AUDIENCE, ARIEL and FLANDERS reply “From the top!”

ARIEL How was that?

DAME It was ok, but the volume wasn’t there. Some of the Audience are wearing louder shirts!

FLANDERS Shall we give it one more go? But this time as loud as we can.

DAME Absolutely. Ready... Where do we start?

The AUDIENCE, ARIEL and FLANDERS reply “From the top!”

DAME Now that’s more like it! Do it just like that every time please! **(Beat)** Right, that’s the end of the lesson. Doesn’t time fly when you’re having fun!

FLANDERS I don’t think **(NAME OF MAN)** was having fun.

DAME Well, he’ll have to practice his scales!

FLANDERS We haven’t heard Ariel sing properly yet.

DAME She can manage that herself. She’s been trained by the most extraordinarily talented vocal coach this side of the Great Barrier Reef.

FLANDERS No she hasn’t, she was trained by you!

DAME Cheek! Now I must dash, I’m expecting a delivery of kelp and Australia Post keep delivering it to the wrong ocean. **(She exits)**

FLANDERS (To ARIEL) I’d still like to hear you sing. You’ve got the most beautiful voice in the sea, and I bet the audience would love to hear it. Wouldn’t you?

The AUDIENCE respond.

ARIEL I suppose I could sing... but I don’t know where to begin.

FLANDERS We can help with that... **(To the AUDIENCE)** Where do we start?

The AUDIENCE reply “From the Top!” ARIEL laughs.

ARIEL Ok, how about this one...

Song: Ariel – PART OF YOUR WORLD

ARIEL sings her solo. **FLANDERS** listens intently.

FLANDERS (After the song ends) That was incredible.

ARIEL blushes. The lighting shifts slightly. She looks up.

ARIEL Hey **FLANDERS**, what's that?

FLANDERS Looks like a ship to me.

ARIEL A ship, with humans on board? Come on, let's go take a look! **(She exits)**

FLANDERS Wait! Your mother said not to... **(Too late, ARIEL has gone)** Oh dear. I've got a bad feeling about this. **(He exits after her)**

An evil chord sounds and OCTAVIA emerges from the shadows. The AUDIENCE boos.

OCTAVIA Oh lovely. Keep going. Let me drink all your boos.

The AUDIENCE boo louder.

Ok that's enough, or I'll be hammered by the interval! **(Beat)** Now then. We haven't been properly introduced, have we? I'm Octavia; Sea-witch, Ariel's aunt and Queen Marina's younger sister. You know, the one they don't put on the family portrait. **(Beat)** I've been standing there the whole time, listening to Ariel sing. Did you hear her?

The AUDIENCE react.

Of course you did. Because it's... extraordinary. I've been chasing that top note since I was fourteen but I could never reach the high Cs! My attempts to sing that high were like a damp firework... they never quite went off! **(Beat)** But Ariel has the perfect voice, and she doesn't even know what it's worth. And even worse... she wants to waste it on *humans*. My sister Marina has the trident, the throne, the title... and now her daughter has something I want too. Well... **(Mischievously)** Two fish, one shell, as they say. **(She gestures upward)** If that ship up there were to run into... difficulties... and if a certain curious princess were to make a rash decision to help them... well. That opens all sorts of doors, for me! **(She laughs wickedly. Calling offstage)** Slip! Slap! Get in here!

SLIP and SLAP enter. SLAP holds a Marvel comic.

SLIP Here we are! Like Captain America answering a distress signal!

SLAP Although technically Iron Man would have been faster...

SLIP Captain America can run thirty miles per hour.

SLAP That's still quite slow.

SLIP It's very fast for a human.

OCTAVIA What are you talking about, **(Noticing the comic)** and what is that?

SLAP It's a Marvel comic, we collect them.

SLIP We've got every issue of Iron Man, most of the Hulk and a few Deadpool's... but we don't read those.

OCTAVIA Why not?

SLIP He keeps breaking the fourth wall. It's very unsettling.

In perfect synchronicity, all three turn to face the AUDIENCE and stare them down for a moment. OCTAVIA continues.

OCTAVIA **(Regarding the ship above)** I want that ship capsized in a great big storm!

SLAP **(Immediately)** Spider-Man can do it!

OCTAVIA What?

SLIP He can web the rigging and bring it down.

OCTAVIA I don't want Spider-Man! I want a storm. A large, violent, ship-sinking storm.

SLIP How about Thor?

SLAP **(Nodding immediately)** Obviously Thor, he's the God of Thunder.

SLIP He'd do it in about five seconds, ten tops!

OCTAVIA I am not calling Thor! I am a sea-witch and I will conjure it myself.

SLIP **(Genuinely surprised)** You can control the weather?

OCTAVIA Of course I can. Now stand back, this is going to be spectacular!

SLIP and SLAP step back. OCTAVIA raises her arms. The lighting churns.

SLAP **(Quietly, to SLIP)** Turns out she can control the weather!

SLIP **(Impressed)** Just like Thor.

OCTAVIA **(Menacingly)** Will you stop going on about superheroes, otherwise I'll knock your teeth out, and then you will be 'Thore!

There is an evil chord as the lights swirl and OCTAVIA laughs.

BLACKOUT. END OF SCENE.

Scene Three: Aboard the Ship

TABS OPEN

A grand ship deck at sea. The ENSEMBLE are sailors on a voyage. EVAN and WILLIS are among them.

CYCLORAMA – BLUE SUNNY DAY ON A GENTLE OCEAN

Song: Evan, Willis and Ensemble – SEA SHANTY

GODFREY (Entering) Do you have to do all that singing while we're at sea?

WILLIS Your majesty, King Godfrey... it raises morale for the sailors.

GODFREY Yes, Willis, but it lowers morale for my ears. Besides, it's bad luck.

EVAN Father, why do you have to be so superstitious? It's just a bit of fun.

GODFREY Oh Prince Evan, my dear, dear boy... Being superstitious is my royal prerogative. Besides, your mother wasn't superstitious and look what happened to her.

EVAN She got crossed by a black cat after walking under a ladder and spilling salt everywhere.

GODFREY Precisely, so who knows what might happen out here at sea.

EVAN I hardly think any of that is going to happen on a boat in the middle of nowhere.

A sailor enters carrying a ladder.

SAILOR Excuse me!

He crosses right in front of GODFREY and EVAN. Another SAILOR enters from the other side. He carries some small boxes marked Salt. The SAILOR with the ladder bumps into him and the Salt boxes fly everywhere.

EVAN Well, at least there isn't a cat!

A fish is thrown on from the wings. WILLIS catches it.

WILLIS No, but this is a cat-fish! **(He pockets it)**

GODFREY See, you can't be too careful. Now, I don't like the look of the ocean, it's too calm.

EVAN But it's just water, father.

GODFREY That's exactly what it wants you to think! It starts all calm and serene and then wham... a splashy betrayal. **(Beat)** Now, I want a weather report.

EVAN You can see the weather is fine, why do you need a report?

GODFREY Because it's my royal prerogative.

SAILOR **(Stepping forward with a report paper)** The weather will be sunny.

Suddenly the stage is incredibly brightly lit.

With gusts of wind

There is a fart sound.

And periodic rain.

Water pistols appear from the wings and spray the audience with water. After a moment the water pistols stop and the lights return to normal.

GODFREY Very good. Now, everyone back to work, we won't get anywhere if we're standing about chatting.

SAILOR But you're standing about chatting?

GODFREY Of course I am, it's my...

Everyone joins in...

ALL Royal prerogative!

GODFREY Exactly! Now, Evan, I need to talk to you.

All the SAILORS get back to work. GODFREY, EVAN and WILLIS talk together.

As you know, we are sailing to find you a suitable romantic match.

EVAN I do, but is that really necessary!

GODFREY Of course, besides, I think you'll be pleasantly surprised by the girls I've got lined up for you. Willis, give us the list.

WILLIS First there is Kelly, a kindly and cultured cutie from Kendenup.

EVAN She sounds nice.

WILLIS Then there's Bella, a brilliant and beautiful baroness from Barker

EVAN She sounds nice too.

WILLIS And finally Penelope, a pretty, prim, proper, polite, playful and perfectly pleasant princess from Porongurup.

EVAN That's a mouthful.

WILLIS So is she, apparently!

GODFREY See, we're sure to find you a match.

EVAN But what if I don't like them, or they don't like me.

GODFREY Nonsense. Of course they'll like you. Now, I'm going below deck to alphabetise the emergency life jackets.

EVAN **(Confused)** Why on earth are you going to do that? **(Realising)** Wait, I know, it's your royal prerogative.

GODFREY Exactly! **(He exits)**

ARIEL and FLANDERS enter at one side as if surfacing near the ship. They can see everyone on board, but can't be seen themselves.

ARIEL Wow, it's incredible!

FLANDERS It certainly is, now come on, we shouldn't be here.

ARIEL But I want to see more, let's just stay a few more minutes.

FLANDERS Fine, but we're not to get any closer.

EVAN and WILLIS continue to talk.

EVAN I don't know why father wants me to marry, I'm perfectly happy on my own.

WILLIS I know that, but getting married is what princes do... It's their royal prerogative.

EVAN **(Laughing)** Don't start that again.

CYCLORAMA – DARK AND STORMY WITH LIGHTNING

Thunder rumbles and lightning flashes. The ship creaks slightly. GODFREY runs on. He is wearing a lifejacket.

GODFREY What was that?

EVAN It's just a bit of thunder and lightning.

Thunder rumbles again, stronger.

GODFREY There it is again! I said the sea was too calm!

EVAN Father, it's just a storm!

GODFREY There's no such thing as 'just a storm'! Storms are nature's way of shouting 'I told you so!'

It thunders again. The ship lurches one way and everyone moves the other.

WILLIS Nature is shouting quite loudly, sir!

More thunder. Throughout the next lines, everyone is being buffeted about the deck as the storm crescendos. In the commotion EVAN exits as he is thrown overboard.

GODFREY It's a good job I'm wearing this lifejacket.

WILLIS What about the lifejackets for the rest of us?

GODFREY Don't worry about them, they're perfectly safe below deck. Besides, I think the storm is stopping.

The storm immediately stops.

CYCLORAM REVERTS TO CALM SEAS

GODFREY Well that wasn't too bad.

WILLIS Not too bad, I think I've broken something. **(He pulls out the fish he caught earlier, it is damaged)** Oh dear, I think this fish got battered!

The SAILORS start to help each other stand up.

GODFREY Now, where is Prince Evan?

Everyone looks around. EVAN cannot be found.

SAILOR He must have fallen overboard?

GODFREY Don't be silly, this isn't the time for independent aquatic exploration!

WILLIS Can anyone see him in the water?

Everyone starts to look out to sea. ARIEL turns to FLANDERS.

ARIEL I can see him, he looks like he's in trouble.

FLANDERS And you will be too if your mother finds out you're here!

ARIEL We have to help him, come on! **(She exits)**

FLANDERS No Ariel, we can't get involved, it's none of our business! **(ARIEL has gone. He sighs)** Fine. I've got a really bad feeling about this! **(He exits after her)**

SAILOR **(To GODFREY)** There's no sign of him, your Majesty.

GODFREY **(Thinking)** Hmm... Ladder, Salt, Catfish, Storm.

WILLIS Are you talking about your superstition, sir?

GODFREY I said they would all happen. **(Beat)** And it's not superstitious if you're right.

WILLIS And if you're wrong?

GODFREY **(Firmly)** Then it's still my royal prerogative.

TABS CLOSE. END OF SCENE.

Scene Four: The Shore**TABS CLOSED**

There is a magical sound as the SPIRIT OF THE SEA appears. As she addresses the AUDIENCE, ARIEL and FLANDERS enter, supporting EVAN between them. They lay him carefully on the shore.

SPIRIT The storm has now calmed, and Evan's been saved,
Ariel kept him safe from a very watery grave,
But what happens now, is anyone's guess,
Who knows what is next for this prince and princess.

There is a magical sound as the SPIRIT OF THE SEA disappears.

FLANDERS (Out of breath) Right. Here we are. The shore. Lovely. Come on Ariel time to go home.

EVAN stirs.

ARIEL He's alive!

FLANDERS That is technically good news. Although emotionally... I'm not convinced. Ariel, we should go. Your mother is going to absolutely lose her fins if she finds out, and we can't let him see us.

ARIEL simply shakes her head. She isn't going anywhere.

(Sighing) Right. **(To the AUDIENCE)** I'll just go and... **(He gestures vaguely at the ocean)** Oh never mind. Besides, I've been out of water for six minutes and I'm beginning to question my entire lifestyle. **(Exits)**

ARIEL and EVAN are alone. EVAN stirs again and opens his eyes. For a moment he is confused, then he sees ARIEL.

EVAN **(Trying to make sense of what he's seeing)** Are you real?

ARIEL Yes, I am. **(With a cheeky glint)** Are you?

EVAN I think so. I hope so. **(Beat)** You saved me.

ARIEL You were sinking.

EVAN I was drowning. **(Beat)** Thank you. **(ARIEL helps him sit up and he looks at her properly for the first time.)** I've never actually spoken to someone from...

ARIEL From the sea?

EVAN No. **(Beat)** Is it strange, being seen by a human?

ARIEL Is it strange, being pulled from the sea by a mermaid?

EVAN Honestly? It's the best thing that's happened to me all week.

ARIEL laughs. EVAN joins in. A romantic tension is growing.

You're fascinated by it all, aren't you. The surface.

ARIEL Always. Aren't you fascinated by the sea?

EVAN My father's tried put me off it. He's suspicious of anything that isn't dry land.

ARIEL My mother doesn't like the surface. She's frightened of anything that isn't underwater.

EVAN What's it like, down there?

ARIEL **(Searching for the right words)** It's beautiful. And safe. And everyone knows who I am and what I'm supposed to be. And no one is interested in anything else or finding out about the world or meeting new people or...

EVAN **(Gently interrupting her)** No one else is... but I am.

Song: Ariel & Evan – TIME OF MY LIFE

They are about to share a romantic moment but are interrupted by GODFREY'S voice calling from offstage.

GODFREY **(Offstage)** Evan! Evan, where are you?

ARIEL **(Startled)** I have to go.

EVAN I'll find you again, I promise.

ARIEL exits quickly. WILLIS enters from the other side.

WILLIS There you are, thank goodness. We thought you'd become... environmentally integrated.

GODFREY **(Entering and looking him over unimpressed)** You look like you've been dragged through the ocean.

EVAN I have been dragged through the ocean.

GODFREY Well. Don't do it again.

WILLIS How did you get to shore?

EVAN Someone brought me here.

GODFREY What do you mean, someone?

EVAN A girl. She saved me, and sang to me with the most extraordinary voice I've ever heard.

GODFREY I didn't know Adele had maritime training

EVAN No, it wasn't Adele, but she was rolling in the deep. **(Beat)** I've got to find her, I have to.

GODFREY Evan, we have a ship to repair, a voyage to resume, and three young ladies expecting a royal introduction. This is not the time for sea-fancies.

EVAN Please father, we just got hit by a ferocious storm, I got swept overboard, nearly drowned and was rescued by a beautiful mermaid with an incredible singing voice. You can't just ignore all that. You must think something of it?

GODFREY I do think something of it... It all sounds very sus-fish-ious to me! **(He exits)**

EVAN and WILLIS look at each other amused and follow.

BLACKOUT. END OF SCENE.

Scene Five: The Bargain

TABS OPEN

CYCLEORAMA – UNDERWATER SCENE

We return underwater. The stage is bustling as DAME BELUGA and the MERMAIDE SISTERS are chattering. THEODORE is trying, and failing to take command.

THEO **(Loudly, to the room)** Right then, the storm is over. All citizens of the Coral are to remain calm, stay in their current positions, and await further instruction while I initiate Aquatic Protocol Seventeen.

DAME What's Aquatic Protocol Seventeen?

THEO **(Slightly less certain)** It's where we all stay calm and don't panic.

DAME And if that doesn't work?

THEO Then we initiate Aquatic Protocol Eighteen.

DAME Which is?

THEO You don't want to know.

MARINA enters. Everyone stops what they are doing.

MARINA Has anyone seen Ariel?

Everyone shakes their head.

DAME **(Helpfully)** We're just on Aquatic Protocol Seventeen, your Majesty.

MARINA **(To THEODORE)** Theodore, are you familiar with Aquatic Protocol Sixty-Three, the one where the Queen wallops her Lobster?

THEO But there is no Aquatic Protocol Sixty-Three.

MARINA There is now!

MARINA whacks THEODORE who stumbles and steps back. FLANDERS and ARIEL enter. FLANDERS is talking to ARIEL and doesn't notice that anyone else is there.

FLANDERS Now listen, we can't say what we were doing, ok. We can't say that we went to look at the surface, or that there was a ship, or anything about the storm, or mention that the prince got thrown overboard, and we mustn't mention that we saved him and took him back to land, and under no circumstances should we talk about how you sang a song together and fell deeply in love. None of that, ok, not a syllable, not a word!

Every face in the room turns to look at FLANDERS. Beat.

(Slowly realising) Oh no... I might have said too much.

MARINA What did you say?

FLANDERS Technically, I didn't say anything. I might have mentioned a ship, some swimming and a cover-up. But I said none of it happened. So, in a sense...

ARIEL **(Through her teeth)** FLANDERS.

FLANDERS stops talking.

MARINA Is it true?

Beat.

ARIEL ...Yes.

MARINA You went to the surface?

ARIEL Yes.

MARINA During the storm?

ARIEL Yes.

MARINA And were watching the ship?

FLANDERS Well actually the storm started after we got there...

MARINA shoots FLANDERS a look and he stops talking. The atmosphere is tense.

THEO **(Trying to help)** Your Majesty... As Her Majesty's Most Loyal Hermit, Guarder of the Oysters, Keeper of the Pearls...

MARINA Not now.

THEO **(Stepping back)** Of course.

DAME **(Raising her hand)** If I could just offer a brief...

MARINA Not you either.

DAME **(To the AUDIENCE, slightly wounded)** I was only going to suggest a breathing exercise.

MARINA You were watching the ship, before the storm? How long were you up there?

FLANDERS (Trying to save things) Only a couple of seconds, a minute tops.

MARINA (Sarcastically) Only a couple of seconds? Well, that seems barely enough time to get to the surface, see the ship, witness a storm and save someone who got thrown overboard.

FLANDERS You forgot about the song!

Both ARIEL and MARINA shoot him a look. He retreats sheepishly.

ARIEL He was drowning! I had to help him...

MARINA No you did not. **(Beat)** My own parents were caught in fishing nets. They were not causing trouble. They were not anywhere dangerous. They were swimming, in their own sea, in the wrong place at the wrong time, and they never came back. **(Beat)** Ariel, I am not angry with you. I am frightened for you. There is a difference, and I need you to understand it, because I cannot bear to lose you too.

ARIEL I know, and I'm sorry. But I saved someone's life last night. And I can't regret that. And I can't keep being sorry for wanting to know more about the world above us. I just can't.

MARINA Ariel, you are my daughter. That is why I will protect you... even from yourself. Now I forbid you to leave the coral, and we'll discuss the rest later.

MARINA exits. Everyone follows. DAME BELUGA hangs behind.

DAME For what it's worth, I thought you were both excellent. Very clear diction, lovely range of dynamics and a superb vocal timbre. **(Exits)**

ARIEL is alone. Beat. There is an evil chord and OCTAVIA enters with SLIP and SLAP lurking behind her. The AUDIENCE boo.

OCTAVIA (To the AUDIENCE) Oh, don't, I'm here to help. **(To ARIEL)** Ariel my dear, what a terrible morning you've had... Your mother is frightened. The prince is unreachable. And you are stuck down here while he is up there, with the entire ocean between you. Sounds like quite the predicament.

SLIP (To SLAP, excitedly) Ooh, I know, this is the bit where Scarlet Witch would just collapse the probability field...

SLAP She'd reach into the multiverse, pull out the version of events where...

OCTAVIA (Patiently) There is no multiverse.

SLIP There's definitely a multiverse.

SLAP Phase Four was very clear about...

OCTAVIA (Sharply) Enough. Leave us.

SLIP and SLAP exit. OCTAVIA breathes and composes herself.

OCTAVIA (To **ARIEL**, charming again) What I am offering is considerably more practical than a multiverse. **(She smiles)** I can give you legs.

ARIEL Human legs?

OCTAVIA Exactly! The kind of human legs that will take you to the surface and help you find your prince.

ARIEL And in return?

OCTAVIA In return, I hold onto that voice of yours while you're up there. Just for safekeeping. You won't need it, you can't exactly explain all of this... **(Gesturing to the underwater world)** on day one.

ARIEL What's the catch?

OCTAVIA **(Pleasantly)** There isn't one.

ARIEL There is always a catch. That's Rule One of catches.

OCTAVIA I promise there isn't. This plan has fewer catches than the Australian cricket team at the Ashes! **(She continues her charm offensive)** Here's the deal; I give you legs, and you give me your voice, temporarily of course. Your voice stays in the shell until released, and the whole thing will be like a walk in the park... or anywhere you like with your new legs! Now, do we have a deal?

OCTAVIA presents an outstretched hand. ARIEL is unsure.

ARIEL I don't know, it all seems too easy.

OCTAVIA And why shouldn't it be. Not everything has to be difficult... like your mother.

ARIEL It would be nice to have my own way for once, but I still don't know. **(She turns to the AUDIENCE)** What do you think, should I make the deal?

The AUDIENCE responds negatively.

Are you sure I shouldn't? She said there wasn't a catch?

The AUDIENCE continue to shout.

ARIEL You all seem very much against it. Especially you **(NAME OF MAN)**

OCTAVIA Don't listen to them Ariel, they just want you to leave so they'll daw the raffle and start supper!

ARIEL Ok, I'll do it!

ARIEL takes OCTAVIA'S hand and they shake. Suddenly a magical transformation begins. The lights flash and a dark, magical sound plays and music swells. By the time the lights go back to normal and the music dies down ARIEL'S transformation is complete and instead of her mermaid's tail she now has two human legs! A beat, ARIEL looks at her new legs.

(Overjoyed) They're amazing!

DAME **(Entering)** What's going on here. I heard all this noise and commotion and I knew it wasn't a male voice choir!

ARIEL Look, Dame Beluga, I've got legs; two brilliant, wonderful, fabulous legs!

DAME Sounds like you've got a thesaurus too!

OCTAVIA I knew you'd like them... and now for your voice.

DAME What about her voice? You can't be doing anything with Ariel's voice; she's my finest pupil!

OCTAVIA Oh Beluga, stop your wailing!

There is another magical sound. A light shines on ARIEL and then travels towards OCTAVIA. She has collected a large seashell from the wings and the light rests upon it before going out.

There, all done.

ARIEL tries to talk, but no sound comes out.

Oh hush, little one, your voice is mine now!

ARIEL and DAME BELUGA look shocked.

DAME Her voice is yours?

OCTAVIA Oh, did I say "mine" I meant it's in this shell. **(Showing the shell)** Whoopsie! Now, off you go, the surface is that way!

ARIEL is excited by her legs, but sad for the loss of her voice. She looks at DAME BELUGA but decides to leave before she changes her mind!

DAME What have you done?

OCTAVIA **(Innocently)** What have I done? She's the one that did it, she's the one who decided to give up her voice for some legs... You can't blame me for this; not really... **(She laughs)**

The AUDIENCE boo.

Oh, please! You lot wouldn't know a happy ending if it came served with fish sauce!

DAME But you can't just steal her voice and put it in a conch, that's shell-fish!

OCTAVIA I haven't stolen it, I've borrowed it... **(Aside)** permanently! **(She laughs)**
Now, if you don't mind, I think I'll be off, evil plans don't make themselves!

There is an evil chord as OCTAVIA exits, laughing manically. MARINA, THEODORE, FLANDERS and the ENSEMBLE enter quickly.

MARINA Where is she? Where is Ariel?

DAME She's gone, your majesty. Octavia gave her legs and took her voice, and now Ariel's gone to the surface to find the prince.

MARINA Then all my fears have come true. My sister has betrayed me and Ariel is lost.

DAME **(Overdramatically falling apart)** It's a disaster!

FLANDERS Come on Dame Beluga, it is bad, but that does seem a little dramatic.

THEO A little dramatic? This is a lot dramatic... it's a complete and utter breakdown of Aquatic Protocol Seventeen!

DAME **(To the AUDIENCE)** Still no sign of Eighteen, then.

THEO **(Trying to recover authority)** Right! New plan! We initiate... Aquatic Protocol Seventeen B!

FLANDERS What's that?

THEO **(Beat)** Panic, but in an organised fashion.

Beat. Then everyone erupts into panic with no organisation.

(Trying to be heard) I said in an organised fashion.

No one takes any notice and continues to panic chaotically.

Oh, I give up.

THEODORE throws his arms up and begins to panic too, arguably worse than everyone else. After a moment a magical sound plays and THE SPIRIT OF THE SEA enters. Everyone stops.

SPIRIT The bargain is sealed and the price has been paid,
Your Ariel walks above, voiceless, afraid.
Octavia holds what was never her own
And plans with that voice to lay claim to the throne.

So here is the task, and there's much to be done,
A great list of things, and you've only just begun:
Get up to the surface, you're needed up there,
Find Ariel quickly, she needs those who care.

TABS CLOSE. END OF SCENE. END OF ACT ONE

Act Two

Scene Six: The Royal Palace

TABS OPEN

CYCLORAMA – INSIDE A GRAND BALLROOM

The Royal Palace is grand and bright. The **ENSEMBLE** as courtiers, guests and guards perform the opening number.

Song: Evan, Willis and Ensemble- CRAB RAVE

As the song ends **EVAN** enters, lost in thought. He looks out over the **AUDIENCE**. **WILLIS** enters after him.

WILLIS Your majesty. **(Beat)** Evan. **(Beat)** Evan.

EVAN Hmm? Sorry, what?

WILLIS Are you ok sir? What are you looking at?

EVAN The sea.

WILLIS Right. And what's in the sea?

EVAN **(Beat)** Water.

WILLIS And?

EVAN Fish.

WILLIS And?

EVAN **(Quietly)** Her.

WILLIS Ah, I see.

EVAN No, the Sea.

GODFREY **(Entering)** Evan! Excellent. Now, Princesses Kelly, Bella, and Penelope are due to arrive this afternoon...

EVAN **(Interrupting)** I'm not interested in them. I want to find the girl from the sea; she saved my life.

GODFREY Oh Evan, just because you went MIA and then the Marine Rescue lady gave you CPR and you started breathing ASAP, it doesn't mean she's HOHILVY!

EVAN What does that mean?

GODFREY Head over heels in love with you! **(He exits, frustrated)**

WILLIS LOL!

ARIEL enters. She has human legs, but cannot speak. She bumps into EVAN as he turns around and he instinctively steadies her as she stumbles slightly.

EVAN It's you.

ARIEL nods. She smiles. She opens her mouth to speak but she can't. She gestures desperately at her throat.

What's wrong? Are you... can you not speak?

ARIEL shakes her head miserably.

At all?

She shakes her head again.

(Taking a step toward her) I don't understand. You could before, and you sang so beautifully...

GODFREY (Entering and interrupting) Evan! The princesses have arrived early and... **(Seeing ARIEL)** Oh, who is this?

EVAN This is the beautiful woman who saved me from the sea.

GODFREY OMG!

EVAN I told you she was real.

GODFREY You told me she was a mermaid, but look, she's got legs. **(To ARIEL)** What is your name?

ARIEL tries to speak but she can't.

GODFREY Come on girl, you must have a name!

ARIEL tries again, but still she makes no sound.

(Exasperated) WTF! (To EVAN) You can't marry someone who can't speak, let alone someone we barely know anything about.

EVAN I know she's got a beautiful singing voice.

GODFREY Oh please, the only thing we know about her, is that she isn't vegan.

EVAN (Confused) How do you know that?

GODFREY If she was, she would have told us already! **(He to EVAN)** Now come on, we need to talk with our guests.

GODFREY leads EVAN and WILLIS away from ARIEL and they mingle with the ENSEMBLE. An evil chord sounds as OCTAVIA enters. SLIP and SLAP follow. The AUDIENCE boo.

OCTAVIA **(Relishing it)** Marvellous. Let it all out. **(To ARIEL, with great warmth)** There she is. My poor sweet silent niece. How are those legs treating you?

ARIEL glares at her.

(To ARIEL, airily) Oh, don't look at me like that. You wanted legs, I gave you legs. A deal's a deal. **(Beat)** What's the problem, catfish got your tongue?
(She laughs) Too bad, but that does give me an idea...

OCTAVIA reveals she is carrying the shell with ARIEL'S voice inside. She taunts her with it.

Remember this?

SLIP **(Helpfully)** This is the part where she does something brilliant!

SLAP Like Doctor Strange with the time stone!

SLIP Or Loki, with glamour and misdirection...

SLAP Bit of chaos.

OCTAVIA Will you two stop it with the Marvel characters already!

SLIP Ooh, someone's coming over all Thanos.

OCTAVIA Get out, now!

SLIP and SLAP exit.

OCTAVIA **(Spotting EVAN)** Aha, there he is... now, let's put this voice to good use, shall we.

OCTAVIA holds the shell up and begins to sing a line from the chorus of the ARIEL and EVAN'S duet from Scene Four. EVAN, across the room, hears it and turns. He recognises the song, but not the singer.

EVAN **(To OCTAVIA)** Who are you?

OCTAVIA Don't you recognise our song?

EVAN I recognise the song, but I don't recognise you. What's going on?

OCTAVIA It's me, I saved you from the shipwreck, surely you remember that?

EVAN But I don't understand. You sound like the one who saved me, but **(indicating ARIEL)** she looks like the girl I remember.

GODFREY comes over to join them.

GODFREY Excuse me, I don't think we've had the pleasure.

OCTAVIA Oh, your majesty, the pleasure is all mine...

GODFREY I couldn't help hear your singing. Your voice is so beautiful I can't believe it!

OCTAVIA **(Savouring it)** Oh, neither can I. It came at quite a price, but then, the most beautiful things always do. It was I who rescued Evan from the storm.

ARIEL tries to intervene but still cannot talk.

GODFREY Please young lady, you've had your fun, now off you go.

ARIEL sighs and exits despondently.

I didn't believe it when Evan told me he was rescued, but here you are! And that gives me an idea. **(Announcing to everyone)** Will you all please gather in the Great Hall, I have an announcement to make.

GODFREY leads OCTAVIA offstage. Everyone follows but EVAN who remains alone. ARIEL enters tentatively carrying a stack of large cue cards. EVAN sees her and is delighted.

EVAN I was hoping you'd come back.

They look at each other for a moment. GODFREY'S voice, from offstage, breaks the tension.

GODFREY **(Off. Calling)** Evan, are you coming?

EVAN **(To GODFREY)** I'll be there in a moment, I'm just talking to someone.

GODFREY **(Off)** Who is it?

ARIEL turns over the cards to reveal the text. Each card is large so the AUDIENCE can clearly read it. The first card says: "Say its Coral Singers"

EVAN **(To GODFREY, offstage)** Its Coral singers.

Musical underscore plays (Suggest 'Silent Night' as per the cue card scene in the film Love Actually) ARIEL starts to go through the cards slowly, showing each one in turn and then passing it offstage as she does. If required, EVAN should read each one out loud.

CARD 1 With any luck, by next year...

CARD 2 I'll be going out with one of these...

CARD 3 contains a large picture of a very weird and strange looking fish. Both ARIEL and EVAN laugh. ARIEL continues to the next card.

CARD 4 And you'll be taking out one of these...

CARD 5 has an image of a plate of Fish and Chips. Again, they both laugh. ARIEL continues with the cards.

CARD 6 But for now, let me say...

Suddenly FLANDERS enters. He is flustered.

FLANDERS Ariel, there you are!

ARIEL looks at him, annoyed. EVAN is confused.

FLANDERS Your mother's looking for you and wants you to come back home.

ARIEL tries to talk to him but she can't.

FLANDERS Yes, I know you can't talk...

EVAN **(Interrupting)** Excuse me, but what's going on?

FLANDERS She's trying to explain, but you're obviously not... reading the signs. **(Beat)** Perhaps she could tell you using ASL?

EVAN Australian Sign Language?

FLANDERS No, Aquatic Sign Language. It's very similar, but instead of using your hands you use your fish fingers.

GODFREY'S voice shouts onstage again.

GODFREY **(Off)** Evan, will you hurry up!

EVAN I have to go.

EVAN rushes offstage. ARIEL watches him longingly.

FLANDERS I'm sorry Ariel.

She looks sad. FLANDERS looks at the cue cards.

What's with the cards? What are they all about?

ARIEL reveals the final card to read the words "They're about LOVE, ACTUALLY"

BLACKOUT. END OF SCENE

Scene Seven: Beneath the Waves

TABS CLOSED

DAME BELUGA enters. She carries one of ARIEL'S cue cards but doesn't show it to the AUDIENCE yet.

DAME Hello everyone, are you having a good time?

The AUDIENCE responds.

Well, that response was a bit *piano*, I wanted a bit more *forte* than that, or at least *mezzo-forte*, but I suppose it's understandable given all that's going on. Ariel has legs but no voice, Octavia seems to be getting in there with King Godfrey and Prince Evan, and all I've got is this picture of a **(NAME OF MAN'S)** ex!

She turns the card around to reveal it is the picture of the weird and strange looking fish from the previous scene.

But enough of that... I've decided to look for Ariel. I can't have my finest student go missing. She's the only pupil I've ever had who didn't make me want to weep into my scales. Trouble is, I have no idea where she is.

MARINA and THEODORE enter.

MARINA Ah, Dame Beluga, there you are. We're going to search for Ariel.

DAME That's what I was going to do. Shall we all go together?

THEO We'll manage without you, thank you.

DAME **(Cheekily/sarcastically)** And remind me, who are you?

THEO I am Lobster Theodore; Her Majesty's Most Loyal Hermit, Guarder of the Oysters, Keeper of the Pearls, Defender of the Reef, and Generally Snappy Dresser!

DAME **(Teasing)** That's a very long name; it must be hard being Hermit of her Majesty's pearls.

THEO I am not the hermit of her Majesty's pearls! I am Lobster Theodore; her Majesty's most loyal...

MARINA **(Interrupting)** Ok Theodore, we get it. And Dame Beluga, leave my pearls out of it! Now let's get going, or we might be stung by a Jellyfish.

DAME But Jellyfish aren't interested in premeditated, illegal and fraudulent financial scams.

MARINA Not that kind of sting.

CURTAINS SLOWLY OPEN
CYCLORAMA – UNDER THE SEA

A JELLYFISH appears behind them. The AUDIENCE shouts.

DAME What are you all shouting about? What? There was a Jellyfish? Where? Behind us? Oh dear, what are we going to do?

THEO We could initiate Aquatic Protocol Twenty-One?

MARINA What's that?

THEO It's where we sing a song while trying to avoid the Jellyfish and the Audience shout to tell us if they see one.

DAME That sounds very specific, and somewhat hastily invented for this very situation, but it'll do the job. What shall we sing?

MARINA How about **(NAME OF SONG)**?

DAME Excellent, I love that one. But which bit, where do we start?

The AUDIENCE respond "From the top!"

That's a very good idea, but for the sake of brevity shall we just do a short chorus instead?

MARINA Agreed. After four... Four!

SONG TBA

DAME BELUGA, THEODORE and MARINA all sing a short refrain. As they are singing a JELLYFISH appears behind them and the AUDIENCE shout. When they finish singing the JELLYFISH exits. (Adlib dialogue as appropriate)

DAME **(To the AUDIENCE)** Why are you shouting? What? There's a Jellyfish? Behind us? Let's have a look then...

They all turn around to look behind them.

ALL There's nothing there!

MARINA Thank you for shouting, but only do it if there actually is a Jellyfish there, ok? Come on, let's keep singing.

DAME BELUGA, THEODORE and MARINA sing again. A JELLYFISH enters behind them and taps MARINA on the shoulder and chases her offstage.

DAME What is it this time? There's a Jellyfish? But we already looked and there was nothing there! What? There is a Jellyfish? Ok, we'd better have a look then.

DAME BELUGA and THEODORE turn around to look behind them.

D & T There's nothing there!

DAME Hang on, where's Queen Marina?

THEO She was there a minute ago. **(To the AUDIENCE)** Did you see where she went? What, she was chased by a Jellyfish? But you said that last time! Come on Dame Beluga, let's just keep singing.

DAME BELUGA and THEODORE sing again. Again, the JELLYFISH enters behind them and taps THEODORE on the shoulder and chases him offstage.

DAME What is it now? Another Jellyfish? I don't believe you. Do you believe them Theodore... wait, where did Theodore go? What he was chased by the Jellyfish? Oh dear, well I suppose I'd better keep singing.

The AUDIENCE responds.

He was chased by the Jellyfish? This is too much; I'm going to keep singing.

DAME BELUGA sings again. The JELLYFISH enters and taunts her.

There's a Jellyfish behind me isn't there? Why didn't you shout and tell me!
(Beat) I suppose I just have to face my fears and confront it!

DAME BELUGA turns to face the JELLYFISH. The JELLYFISH takes one look at her, screams and runs offstage. DAME BELUGA turns to the AUDIENCE.

Oh dear, I think the Jellyfish had a wobble! **(She exits, chuckling to herself)**

There is a magical sound as THE SPIRIT OF THE SEA enters.

SPIRIT Our heroes are scattered, bedraggled and damp,
Their spirits still burning, but the dame is still camp.
They're heading for Octavia, brave, if confused,
A lobster, a Dame and a queen, unamused.
And Ariel? She's coming, still silent, still strong,
Her voice in a shell, but it won't be held long.
The shell cannot hold what was never hers to take,
The tide will now turn for Ariel's sake.

There is a magical sound as THE SPIRIT OF THE SEA exits.

BLACKOUT. END OF SCENE

Scene Eight: Octavia's Lair

CYCLORAMA – DARK DINGY CAVE (MAYBE FISH BONES / WEIRD JARS OF STUFF ETC. LAYING AROUND)

TABS OPEN

The stage is dark, dramatic and theatrical. The Shell, with ARIEL's voice inside, sits upon a plinth and is lit with a spotlight. OCTAVIA is surrounded by the ENSEMBLE as horrid looking fish and other sea-creatures. She leads them in song.

Song: Octavia and Ensemble – POOR UNFORUNATE SOULS

OCTAVIA All my plans are coming together; deliciously, deviously, and on schedule. **(She calls offstage)** Slip! Slap!

SLIP and SLAP enter. SLIP has a homemade Captain America shield (made from a Frisbee, or similar) SLAP wears a homemade Ironman Gauntlet (a washing-up glove with a torch taped to it)

S & S **(Proudly)** Avengers assemble!

SLIP **(Raising his shield)** I am Captain America!

SLAP **(Raising the gauntlet)** And I am Iron Man!

OCTAVIA Don't be ridiculous. You're wearing a washing-up glove with a torch taped to it.

SLAP It's a Repulsor Beam.

OCTAVIA It's a rubber glove.

SLIP Captain America never had this problem.

OCTAVIA **(Dismissively)** Captain America had a super-serum, a vibranium shield and the moral high ground. You, on the other hand, have a Frisbee. **(Beat)** Now. I have news.

SLIP **(Excited)** Ooh. Is it good news?

OCTAVIA As you know, I convinced King Godfrey that I, not my wretched silent niece, am the woman who saved Prince Evan's life. **(Savouring it)** And tonight, he gave his blessing for Evan to marry... me!

SLAP **(Gasping)** You're going to be a princess?!

OCTAVIA A Princess of the land and the Queen of the Sea. Once I get my hands on my sister's Trident that is! **(She laughs manically)**

SLIP Now that does sound very Doctor Doom!

OCTAVIA It won't be long before I have the Trident, **(Indicating the Shell)** and I already have Ariel's voice, and what a voice it is! **(Regaining composure)** But seeing as you two are about as useful as a cat-flap on a submarine, I want to be very clear about something; you are not to say a word of this to anyone, I don't want to let the cat out of the bag!

SLIP You mean the feline out of the submersible!

OCTAVIA Oh Slip, you are a wet fish! Now get out, all of you, or I'll have you served with tartar sauce!

OCTAVIA, SLIP, SLAP and the ENSEMBLE exit. Beat. DAME BELUGA enters followed by MARINA, FLANDERS and THEODORE.

DAME This must be Octavia's lair; the décor is very tentacle-chic.

MARINA Indeed, but we still haven't found Ariel.

DAME **(Noticing the shell)** No, but look, this shell is where Octavia put Ariel's voice when she gave her legs.

FLANDERS In any other situation that sentence would be considered nuts, but here it makes perfect sense!

MARINA How do we get the voice out?

DAME Can't be too hard, now let me see...

DAME BELUGA begins to inspect the shell.

THEO Are you sure we should be doing that without Ariel here?

DAME Nonsense, it'll be fine. Aha! **(She does something to open the shell)**

There is a magical sound and the lights start flashing.

MARINA What's going on?

FLANDERS No idea, but it looks like we're at Eve Late Night Bar.

The lights stop flashing. The spotlight on the shell has gone off and an identical spotlight appears on DAME BELUGA.

MARINA What just happened?

FLANDERS No idea, but I don't think we're at Eve Late Night Bar.

By opening the shell, ARIEL'S voice was released. It has attached itself to DAME BELUGA who now speaks with ARIEL'S voice. (ARIEL is actually just

offstage, timing her speech with DAME BELUGA'S lips moving.) From now on, each time the spotlight lands on someone else, ARIEL'S voice passes to them.

DAME (In ARIEL'S voice) Luckily nothing strange happened. (Beat) Woah, that's not my voice!

MARINA No, it's Ariel's.

DAME (In ARIEL'S voice) Well, she isn't here, so I'll have it for safekeeping. How about a quick sing... (She sings with ARIEL'S voice)

MARINA Stop that, immediately, or I'll stop it for you!

THEO Aha, Aquatic Protocol Sixty-Three.

MARINA Give my daughter's voice back. Now (She shakes DAME BELUGA)

The lights flash and there is a magical sound. The spotlight disappears from DAME BELUGA and now appears over FLANDERS.

DAME What just happened?

FLANDERS (In ARIEL'S voice) I've got a bad feeling about this. (He claps both his hands over his mouth)

MARINA Oh no, you're not getting the voice either.

MARINA goes to shake FLANDERS. FLANDERS starts shaking her back. THEODORE is cross FLANDERS is doing so and attempts to pull FLANDERS away.

THEO I command you to stop that, as Lobster Theodore; Her Majesty's Most Loyal Hermit...

The lights flash again and the light moves from FLANDERS to THEODORE. ARIEL'S voice jumps to THEODORE as he finishes his sentence.

(In ARIEL'S voice) ...Guarder of the Oysters, Keeper of the Pearls, Defender of the Reef, and Generally Snappy Dresser!

MARINA Now you've got Ariel's voice!

THEO (Still in ARIEL'S voice) I'm so sorry your Majesty, I didn't mean to get it.

THEODORE touches MARINA'S shoulder apologetically. The lights flash and the spotlight moves to MARINA.

MARINA (In a male voice (Also spoken/mimed by someone offstage)) But I don't want Ariel's voice. (Beat. Horrified) I don't want this voice either!

Everyone is confused.

FLANDERS Whose voice is it?

DAME I know... it's **(NAME OF MAN'S)**!

MARINA Oh dear!

DAME **(Shaking MARINA)** Give it back to me

FLANDERS **(Shaking MARINA)** No, I'll take it.

THEO **(Also shaking Marina)** Give it to me!

Suddenly all the lights go haywire and magical sounds play. Everyone braces and then the lights go back to normal. In the commotion ARIEL enters. The spotlight settles on her.

DAME Where did it go? Who's got Ariel's voice.

ARIEL **(Speaking in her own voice)** I have.

From now on everyone speaks with the correct voices again. They are all pleased to see her.

MARINA Oh Ariel, I thought I'd lost you! Tell us everything that's happened.

ARIEL I bet a lot's happened to you too?!

DAME Well, where do we start?

The AUDIENCE respond "From the top!" A beat. SLIP and SLAP interrupt.

SLIP Excuse me, but you're not supposed to be here!

SLAP Oh no, Ariel's got her voice back... what are we going to do, that'll really put a spanner in Octavia's wedding plans!

DAME What wedding?

SLIP Octavia's going to marry Prince Evan, and then she's going to steal the trident and rule both the land and the sea!

Beat. Everyone stops and stares at SLIP

SLAP Um... She told us not to tell anyone that.

FLANDERS **(Mischievously)** Looks like someone's had a Slip-up!

ARIEL We need to get to that wedding, now.

SLAP Not so fast, or we'll catch you, like Spiderman!

SLIP But I'm not Spiderman, I'm Slip!

SLAP Alright, like Slipper-Man!

FLANDERS What are you going to do, throw comfortable shoes at us!

SLAP No, but this lot will!

Several ENSEMBLE members enter, armed with Slippers.

DAME Run!

DAME BELUGA, ARIEL, MARINA, FLANDERS and THEODORE scatter and run. The ENSEMBLE fire their Water-Pistols at them, catching the AUDIENCE in the cross fire! Music plays as everyone exits in the melee.

TABS CLOSE. END OF SCENE

Scene Nine: Back on Dry Land

TABS CLOSED

EVAN and WILLIS enter, both wearing inflatable armbands.

WILLIS So remind me, sir, why are we wearing armbands?

EVAN Because once I marry the girl from the sea, I'll need to be able to swim. I can't have a water-wife if I can't swim, can I?

WILLIS No sir, and are you sure 'water-wife' is the correct term?

EVAN I can't very well call her a fish-wife, can I? **(Beat)** Now, word has it that you're the most accomplished swimmer in the royal household.

WILLIS Yes sir. I know all the techniques... doggie paddle, breaststroke, backstroke, butterfly...

EVAN What choo talking about Willis?

WILLIS Diff'rent Strokes.

GODFREY enters. He is wearing inflatable armbands on both arms, and a rubber ring around his waist. He carries two more rubber rings.

GODFREY (Handing them each a rubber ring) Here. Take these.

EVAN Father, we're on dry land.

GODFREY Yes, and you're about to marry a fish, so I'm not taking any chances!

WILLIS (Looking at his rubber ring) Your majesty, what do you want us to do with these?

GODFREY I want you to wear them.

EVAN That reminds me, I saw what you wanted me to wear for the wedding ceremony, and I'm not sure it's appropriate.

GODFREY Nonsense, a wetsuit is still a suit!

WILLIS And are you sure this is a good idea?

GODFREY Of course it's a good idea, you'll drown if you don't wear it.

WILLIS I meant the wedding, sir.

GODFREY The wedding will be fine. The ring is non-negotiable.

WILLIS Ok, but I've got this funny feeling that something isn't quite right.

EVAN What do you mean, that something's fishy?

WILLIS Everything seems too easy, and, apart from her singing voice, your bride to be isn't anything like you described. Are you sure you're marrying the right person?

GODFREY Of course he is! Don't listen to him Evan. Follow your heart... and Beyonce!

EVAN and WILLIS are confused.

E & W What?!?

GODFREY If you like it, put a rubber-ring on it!

EVAN and WILLIS laugh.

EVAN That joke was terrible.

GODFREY I know, but it's still my royal prerogative! **(He exits)**

WILLIS **(To EVAN)** Are you coming?

EVAN In a minute.

WILLIS exits. EVAN is alone.

There is a magical sound and THE SPIRIT OF THE SEA appears.

SPIRIT You're standing still while the others have gone,
Is something the matter, or something not wrong?
A wedding day jitter, or something more true?
You can trust in me, I'm here just for you!

EVAN I'm not sure. I'm getting married today and I should be excited, but I can't stop thinking about that song.

SPIRIT A song can be borrowed, a song can be learned,
But some songs are carried; they cannot be earned.
You first heard her voice after the storm,
It went straight to your soul and kept your heart warm,

Then later again, you heard on dry ground,
The very same voice, the very same sound,
But something was different, you know it down deep,
So, tell me, who chooses the voice that they keep.

EVAN I don't understand, I don't know what to do.

SPIRIT Don't worry, Dear Evan, just play your part,
And you'll soon hear the voice that sings to your heart!

There is a magical sound as lights dim.

BLACKOUT. END OF SCENE

Scene Ten: The Wedding

TABS OPEN

**CYCLORAM – OUTDOORS AT THE ROYAL PALACE – WEDDING FLOWERS
ETC**

The Royal Palace in its full splendour, dressed for a wedding. The ENSEMBLE as courtiers and wedding guests fill the stage. KING GODFREY stands at the front, officiating. EVAN stands beside him.

GODFREY We are gathered here today, in the sight of the sea, the sky, and an audience of strangers, to celebrate the marriage of my son, Prince Evan, to the woman who saved his life. A woman of great beauty, extraordinary talent, and a voice that stops you in your tracks.

EVAN Stop, father, I don't think I can do this.

GODFREY What are you talking about, isn't this what you wanted?

EVAN I've just got this funny feeling.

GODFREY It's probably indigestion.

WILLIS To tell the truth, I've got a funny feeling too.

GODFREY I didn't know indigestion was contagious!

There is an evil chord. OCTAVIA enters in bridal costume. The AUDIENCE boo. SLIP and SLAP follow, each wearing a homemade superhero cape.

OCTAVIA **(Relishing the boos)** Marvellous. All for me.

SLIP We look amazing.

SLAP We look like superheroes.

OCTAVIA What Superheroes are you trying to look like this time? Superman? Aquaman?

SLAP Oh no, we only like Marvel Superheroes and those two are under DC!

SLIP **(To the AUDIENCE)** Under the Sea/Under DC... Get it? We've been building up to that joke all show!

GODFREY **(Beginning the ceremony)** We are here to join these two in matrimony. If anyone knows of any reason why they should not be married, speak now or...

DAME BELUGA, MARINA, THEODORE, FLANDERS and ARIEL burst onstage.

DAME Stop the wedding!

GODFREY Who are you?

MARINA I am Queen Marina of the Sea and I demand you stop this wedding now!

GODFREY You can't demand that.

MARINA I can, it's my royal prerogative!

GODFREY The royal prerogative's mine, besides, I don't trust you, and we have nothing in common!

THEO How very dare you, for this is Queen Marina and I am Lobster Theodore...

DAME **(Quickly interrupting)** Alright, Theodore, we don't have time for that, or we'll never get to the end of the panto!

OCTAVIA What are you talking about? This is a wedding, not a pantomime.

FLANDERS I think you'll find it's both!

OCTAVIA Oh no it isn't!

ALL Oh yes it is!

OCTAVIA Oh no it isn't!

ALL Oh yes it is!

OCTAVIA Isn't, isn't, isn't!

ALL Is, is, is!

OCTAVIA Fine, it is both, but we're getting married, NOW!

EVAN **(Noticing ARIEL)** Hang on a minute, I recognise you... You had those cards, and I'm sure I've seen you somewhere else too?

OCTAVIA Rubbish! She's just an insignificant nobody. Now let's get on with it.

MARINA How dare you! She isn't an insignificant nobody, she's my daughter, and heir to this trident! **(She raises the trident)**

OCTAVIA **(Unable to hold her charade any longer)** Oh will you stop it with the trident, yes, you're ruler beneath the waves, but it should have been me, so I tricked Ariel into giving me her voice so I could fool Prince Evan into marrying me and it's not fair, it just isn't fair!

Everyone is stunned.

EVAN What did you just say?

OCTAVIA (Trying to regain her composure) Um... I... (She can't)

EVAN I thought you were the one who saved me and I was going to marry you.

Both MARINA and GODFREY speak at the same time.

M & G (Pointing at OCTAVIA) Arrest her!

GUARDS arrest OCTAVIA.

(To each other) What did you just say?

DAME You both tried to have Octavia arrested, seems like that's one thing you do have in common!

EVAN And, unless I'm mistaken, (indicating ARIEL) You're the one who saved me, you're the one with the beautiful voice and that means... you're the one I want to marry.

OCTAVIA She can't be! She can't even talk, let alone sing.

DAME Of course she can sing, she's had the best singing teacher in the Seven Seas! Go on Ariel, show them what you can do!

ARIEL sings a line from their song. Everyone is amazed, OCTAVIA scowls.

ARIEL Sorry Aunt Octavia, I've got my voice back and I'm never letting it go again!

GODFREY (To MARINA) Would you like to do the honours, or shall I?

MARINA It would be my pleasure... (To the GUARDS) Take her away and lock her in the deepest part of the ocean!

OCTAVIA No! Not the Marina's Trench!

The GUARDS march OCTAVIA offstage. EVAN and ARIEL talk.

EVAN It is really you?

ARIEL Are you still afraid to talk to mermaids?

EVAN No, are you scared to be seen by humans?

They both laugh.

ARIEL So what do we do now!

WILLIS It seems a shame to go to all this effort and not have a wedding.

EVAN But we only met 20 pages ago, that's hardly the basis for marriage.

ARIEL It's alright, I'm game if you are.

GODFREY Well in that case... We are gathered here today, in the sight of the sea, the sky, an audience of strangers and... **(He pauses)** No this isn't right.

EVAN and ARIEL look worried.

No, no, I mean that, if you two are getting married, then I need to change my thinking about the sea. I've always been sceptical, but I think it's time I opened my mind and looked for the good that's out there too.

MARINA He's right. I have good reason to be fearful of the land, but perhaps it doesn't hurt to take a step back and reassess every now and again.

There is a magical sound and THE SPIRIT OF THE SEA appears.

SPIRIT A voice was once stolen, a bargain once made,
A princess once silenced, a trick once well-played.
But love has a way of undoing the wrong,
It returned what was stolen, and gave back her song.

Two worlds stood apart, kept by fear and by grief,
But this girl and this boy were the start of relief.
And if two rulers here, from the land and the sea,
Can stand side by side, well, that's how it should be.

There's just one more thing, these two must be wed,
Vows must be made and words must be said
Our ending is here, and the moment's upon us...
So Marina and Godfrey, will you do the honours?

GODFREY and MARINA speak together.

G & M By the power vested in us, we now pronounce you... husband and mermaid!

Everyone cheers.

Song: Full Cast – ABSOULTY EVERYONE

TABS CLOSE. END OF SCENE

Scene Twelve: Finale/Bows

Music. The cast take their bows and line up across the front of the stage.

ARIEL Our story is now over, there's no more left to tell,
EVAN We had quite the adventure, and lots of fish as well,
MARINA I learned that courage is sometimes letting go,
GODFREY I learned the sea's not scary with a rubber ring in tow,
OCTAVIA I learned that wickedness is always doomed to fail
DAME And **(NAME OF MAN)** learned to sing, I saved us from his wail!
FLANDERS The moral of our story is that love will never tremble,
SLIP You can be your own hero...
SLAP And Avengers can assemble.

DAME BELUGA stops the rhyme.

DAME What are you talking about?
SLIP & SLAP Sorry!
SPIRIT The crux of our adventure is that love and truth will out,
THEO And to use the voice you have to sing so very loud!
EVAN We're glad that you could join us, our thanks is so sincere,
ARIEL So all that's left to say is...
ALL See you again next year!

SONG – PIRATES OF THE CARIBBEAN THEME SONG